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Art normally imitates life. In the case of movie star Sanjay Dutt, the opposite seems to be true. If someone had suggested a movie on his life, the script would most likely have been thrown out as too improbable. Dutt went from being the problem child of a famous Bollywood couple to a man accused of a role in India's worst terrorist bombing, from a jail inmate to once again becoming a hugely popular actor and then, back in jail as a convict. In just over a decade he has gone to hell and back.

Dutt's life has been full of ironies. After 16 months in jail for possessing illegal weapons, he was released on bail in 1995. In 12 years that followed, he became Bollywood's renaissance man. Dutt rebuilt his career to a point where he was a bankable star again. He was associated not with the image of a public villain but with 'Munnabhai', the good-hearted gangster of the underworld kind he was found guilty of associating with. The irony does not end there. In the even more successful *Munnabhai* sequel, the character shared a mystical relationship with the spirit of Mahatma Gandhi and practised 'Gandhigiri'. All the while, the shadow of the Mumbai blasts case hung over Dutt. Finally this week, the long arm of the law caught up with his soaring career.

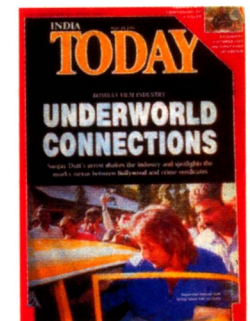
Bollywood stardom had allowed Dutt to ride above the blasts case and resurrect his career. When he was acquitted of terror charges related to the bombings and the case taken out of the draconian TADA court amidst some controversy, it was widely expected he would receive probation.

But, putting the case completely into perspective, Judge Pramod Kode sentenced Dutt to six years' rigorous imprisonment for possession of arms received from key accused. Kode stated that he could not treat Dutt's case as a "minor offence" and said, "Everyone makes mistakes, but the element of criminality in you is incurable." It was a proud day for our much-maligned judicial system that it did not get taken in by the huge wave of public sympathy for the movie star and the din of celebritydom which surrounded him. The wheels of justice ground slowly but surely. The serial bombings in Mumbai claimed 257 lives, and punishing the guilty has taken 14 years, 686 witnesses and 13,000 pages of testimony. Dutt is one of the 50 convicted who will serve between three and 14 years in jail, with judge Kode sentencing 12 to death and 20 to a life behind bars.

Our cover story this week is a look both at the eventful life of Sanjay Dutt and the extraordinary court case he was a part of. Senior Editor Malini Bhupta in Mumbai put together the story along with Senior Correspondent Aditi Pai. They spoke to legal experts and those in Bollywood to find out what lies ahead for the charismatic actor.

Dutt will get his chance to appeal once again. It will be interesting to see whether life will now imitate art and his story will have a happy Bollywood ending.

(Aroon Purie)



Our May 1993 cover